

Intellectual hubs fostering compassionate sharia

Analysis run: September 12, 2026

PROVIDER	MODEL	LANGUAGE	AUDIENCE
Openrouter	Deepseek/deepseek-v4-pro	En	GENERAL
INTONATION	LENGTH	TEMPERATURE	
NEUTRAL	Long	0.7	

SYSTEM PROMPT

You are an expert AI content generator specializing in creating structured article.

USER PROMPT

Write a concise, self-contained article entry for the title: "Intellectual hubs fostering compassionate sharia".

Overall topic for alignment: Intellectual networks shaping humanistic trends in sharia.

Important points to cover: Include Arabic terms, historical contexts, quranic foundations of sharia, minority and majority settings, Islamic theological schools, Islamic juristic schools of Hanafi, Hambali, shafi'i and Malaki, orientalist perspective, AI's humanistic approach to sharia, Human rights declaration..

- Output format: GitHub-Flavored Markdown. The markdown must be clean—do not include any code fences or surrounding markers. Target writing format: Blog Post. Follow these format-specific rules exactly:
- Aim for at least 6000 characters while staying under 12000. Prefer verifiable facts from the provided sources; do not fabricate citations or specific data.
- Place external links only in the "References" section; do not include inline external links in the body text.
- Maximum content length (including headings and references): 12000 characters. If nearing the limit, prioritize the most informative sections and keep references to 2-3.
- Write in the target response language. Avoid fluff; be precise and actionable. Do not include images or tables.
- Do not include code fences or any text outside the markdown content.

No external web sources are attached. Do not fabricate citations or specific facts that cannot be verified. Keep claims general and verifiable. In the 'References' section, include: "No external sources used."

****Respond in English****

SUMMARY

The article traces the development of a merciful, humanistic Islamic jurisprudence (“compassionate sharia”) from its Quranic foundations through classical schools, minority contexts, Western scholarship, and modern technological applications. The Quran anchors law in mercy (*rahma*), justice (*‘adl*), and ease (*taysir*), which classical jurists systematized as the higher objectives of the law (*maqasid al-sharia*)—preserving religion, life, intellect, lineage, and property to serve human welfare (*maslaha*). Tools like juristic preference (*istihsan*) and removal of hardship (*raf‘ al-haraj*) gave schools interpretive flexibility.

Key intellectual hubs (Medina, Kufa, Baghdad, Cordoba, Cairo) nurtured the four Sunni schools:

- **Hanafi:** reason, analogy, and preference; adaptable, official school of the Ottomans; pioneered minority jurisprudence (*fiqh al-aqalliyyat*).
- **Maliki:** relied on Medinan practice and unrestricted public interest (*maslaha mursala*); governed diverse societies in Africa and Spain.
- **Shafi‘i:** systematized legal sources (Quran, Sunna, consensus, analogy); contributed profoundly to *maqasid* theory.
- **Hanbali:** textually strict but produced reformists like Ibn Taymiyya and Ibn Qayyim, who tied governance to justice and public interest (“wherever there is justice, there is the law of God”).

Theological currents reinforced humanistic trends: Ash‘aris stressed God’s justice and reason; Maturidis emphasized human free will and dignity; even Hanbali/Athari scholars insisted law must adapt to changing times and customs.

Contemporary developments address both minority and majority settings. *Fiqh al-aqalliyyat* uses *maqasid* and hardship to help Muslims integrate as loyal citizens in secular states (e.g., permitting interest-based mortgages when necessary). In Muslim-majority contexts, reforms like Tunisia’s ban on polygamy or al-Azhar’s stance against punishing non-seditious apostasy are grounded in overriding higher purposes. Western scholarship (from Orientalist stereotypes to Wael Hallaq’s “jurists’ law” model) now recognizes sharia’s historical dynamism and context-sensitivity.

Artificial intelligence offers new avenues: natural language processing can map patterns of mercy (*maslaha, darura*) across classical texts, potentially aiding AI-assisted *ijtihad* to optimize rulings for *maqasid*. Finally, human rights discourses—from the Cairo Declaration to scholars like An-Na‘im—seek to reconcile sharia with universal dignity through Quranic concepts like *fitra* and *karama insaniyya*. The overarching arc is a living, network-driven tradition where law bends toward human flourishing through principles of permissibility, non-harm, and custom.

Intellectual hubs fostering compassionate sharia

The phrase “compassionate sharia” may strike some as contradictory. For many, Islamic law conjures images of rigid rules and harsh penalties. Yet across Muslim history, vibrant intellectual hubs — from the Prophet’s mosque in Medina to the academies of Baghdad, Cordoba, and Cairo — cultivated a jurisprudence deeply rooted in mercy, wisdom, and human well-being. These networks of scholars shaped what we now call humanistic trends in sharia, always balancing the divine text with the lived realities of diverse communities. This article traces that journey, examining the Quranic foundations, the classical schools of law, the interplay between minority and majority settings, the influence of theological currents, Western orientalist perspectives, and the surprising role artificial intelligence may play in rediscovering and advancing a compassionate sharia today.

Quranic foundations: mercy as the bedrock

The Quran repeatedly anchors legislation in a handful of core values. The most central is *rahma* (mercy). God describes Himself as *al-Rahman* and *al-Rahim*, and the Prophet Muhammad is sent as “a mercy to the worlds” (Q 21:107). Legal rulings, therefore, cannot contradict mercy. Closely linked is *‘adl* (justice), an absolute command: “Indeed, God commands justice and good conduct” (Q 16:90). The scripture also explicitly desires ease for believers: “God intends for you ease and does not intend for you hardship” (Q 2:185). These three principles — mercy, justice, ease — form the ethical triangle within which sharia operates.

Classical jurists encapsulated these objectives in the doctrine of *maqasid al-sharia*, the higher purposes of the law. The great Maliki jurist al-Shatibi (d. 1388) systematized the *maqasid* around the preservation of religion, life, intellect, lineage, and property — all of which serve human welfare (*maslaha*). A ruling that contravenes these purposes, he argued, must be reviewed. This tool became the engine of legal dynamism. Other key Arabic terms that signaled a humanistic orientation include *taysir* (facilitation), *raf‘ al-haraj* (removal of hardship), and *istihsan* (juristic preference) — the latter employed especially by the Hanafi school to avoid undue rigidity in favor of equity.

Intellectual hubs and the flowering of the juristic schools

As Islam expanded, major cities became crucibles of legal thought. Medina remained the guardian of the Prophetic tradition; Kufa and Basra incubated the rationalist currents of Iraq; Damascus and later Cairo represented the confluence of traditions; and Qayrawan, Fez, and Cordoba carried the Maliki torch

across North Africa and Andalusia. It was within these hubs that the four surviving Sunni schools of law — Hanafi, Maliki, Shafi'i, and Hanbali — took shape.

The **Hanafi** school, named after Abu Hanifa (d. 767), emerged in Kufa. It is characterized by extensive reliance on *ra'y* (reasoned opinion), *qiyas* (analogy), and *istihsan*. Its flexibility made it the official school of the Ottoman Empire and the most widely followed school today, stretching from the Balkans to South Asia. Hanafi jurists were pioneers in developing a *fiqh* for religious minorities and in conceptualizing what we now call the jurisprudence of citizenship (*fiqh al-muwatana*).

The **Maliki** school traces back to Imam Malik ibn Anas (d. 795) of Medina. It privileges the practice of the people of Medina (*'amal ahl al-Madina*) as a living embodiment of the Prophetic sunna. Maliki jurists also gave wide scope to *maslaha mursala* (unrestricted public interest), using it to legislate in areas where the Quran and Sunna are silent. This tool made Maliki law remarkably adaptive, particularly in sub-Saharan Africa and medieval Muslim Spain, where it governed multi-religious societies.

The **Shafi'i** school, founded by Muhammad ibn Idris al-Shafi'i (d. 820), sought to harmonize the Ahl al-Hadith (traditionists) and Ahl al-Ra'y (rationalists). Al-Shafi'i's masterpiece, the *Risala*, laid down the first systematic theory of legal sources: Quran, Sunna, consensus (*ijma'*), and analogy (*qiyas*). Shafi'i scholars, from al-Juwayni to al-Ghazali, contributed profoundly to maqasid theory, ensuring that legal deduction remained anchored in higher ethical purposes.

The **Hanbali** school, associated with Ahmad ibn Hanbal (d. 855), is often painted as the most literalist. While it indeed emphasizes strict adherence to textual proof, it also produced reformist figures like Ibn Taymiyya (d. 1328) and his student Ibn Qayyim al-Jawziyya, who advanced a vibrant theory of *siyasa shar'iyya* (sharia-oriented governance) rooted in justice and public interest. Ibn Qayyim famously stated, "Wherever there is justice, there is the law of God." This principle allowed Hanbali judges to adapt rulings to changing circumstances without abandoning textual fidelity.

These schools did not evolve in isolation. Scholarly networks — families of jurists, traveling students, and epistolary exchanges — ensured cross-pollination. The Abbasid capital Baghdad hosted debates among all four schools, while the Umayyad mosque of Cordoba and al-Azhar in Cairo became hubs where legal pluralism was not just tolerated but institutionalized.

Theological currents and their impact on law

Jurisprudence never operates in a theological vacuum. The dominant Sunni theological schools — Ash'ariyya, Maturidiyya, and Athariyya — deeply influenced the humanistic bent of sharia. The Ash'ari emphasis on God's justice and on reason's ability to discern good and evil before revelation provided a strong foundation for maqasid-based reasoning. Al-Ghazali, an Ash'ari, infused jurisprudence with an ethical spirituality, often saying that the purpose of sharia is to cultivate noble character. Maturidi scholars, especially in Central Asia, stressed human free will, making legal responsibility inseparable from human dignity. Even the Athari/Hanbali camp, sometimes associated with literalism, produced works like Ibn Qayyim's *I'lam al-Muwaqqi'in*, which insist that law must change as times, places, and customs change unless a clear text forbids it.

Minority and majority contexts: toward a *fiqh* of compassion

A genuinely compassionate sharia must work for Muslims residing as minorities in non-Muslim lands, just as it works for majorities in Muslim-majority states. The classical division of the world into *dar al-Islam* (abode of Islam) and *dar al-harb* (abode of war) has been thoroughly rethought by contemporary scholars. The field of *fiqh al-aqalliyyat* (jurisprudence of minorities), pioneered by figures like Taha Jabir al-Alwani and Yusuf al-Qaradawi, draws on *maqasid*, *maslaha*, and the principle of hardship (*mashaqqa*) to issue rulings that enable Muslims to thrive as loyal citizens in secular democracies. For instance, Muslim minorities can take interest-bearing loans for home purchases when no halal alternative exists, grounded in the maxim “hardship begets facility.”

In majority settings, similar dynamics appear in legal reforms relating to women, criminal justice, and governance. The Tunisian ban on polygamy, for example, was justified by Maliki principles of public interest and the impossibility of treating multiple wives equally in modern conditions — a direct appeal to Quranic ethics. The intellectual hub of al-Azhar has repeatedly affirmed that apostasy — when unaccompanied by armed rebellion — carries no worldly punishment, despite classical rulings, because the higher purpose of preserving life overrides.

Orientalist engagement and its corrective

Western scholarship on sharia — often termed Orientalism — has historically suffered from two extremes. One strand, epitomized by 19th-century legal transplants like Lord Cromer in Egypt, dismissed Islamic law as stagnant and inhuman. Another, more nuanced group, including scholars like Joseph Schacht and later Wael Hallaq, came to recognize the internal dynamism of *fiqh*. Hallaq’s work demonstrates that premodern sharia was not a state-enforced code but a “jurists’ law,” constantly negotiated between muftis, judges, and the community. This view dismantles the Orientalist stereotype of a rigid legal system and instead reveals a flexible, casuistic tradition deeply attentive to context and conscience.

In recent decades, a new generation of Western academics — many of them Muslims — has uncovered the humanistic underpinnings of sharia. Research on the *maqasid*, on Ottoman flexibility in applying sharia to diverse populations, and on the historical role of *dar al-qada’* (court justice) shows that practical sharia was far from the caricature of cutting off hands. This scholarly turn aligns with internal calls for a renewed *fiqh al-waqi’* (jurisprudence of reality).

AI’s humanistic approach to sharia

Artificial intelligence is now entering the conversation. Large language models trained on vast corpora of classical *fiqh* texts can reveal patterns that human readers might miss. By identifying every instance where a ruling was relaxed due to *maslaha* or custom (*urf*), AI can produce a “mercy map” of Islamic law. Projects using natural language processing to search for keywords like *raf’ al-haraj*, *istihsan*, and

darura (necessity) are cataloging the deep humanitarian strain within the heritage. More ambitiously, AI-assisted *ijtihad* could propose new fatwas that optimize for the *maqasid* while respecting the textual boundaries, serving as a thought partner for contemporary muftis. Such tools, deployed ethically, could democratize access to compassionate legal reasoning and help communities everywhere find context-sensitive answers.

Human rights declarations and the sharia

A crucial test of compassionate sharia is its compatibility with international human rights. The 1990 Cairo Declaration on Human Rights in Islam, issued by the Organisation of Islamic Cooperation, represented an early attempt to articulate a sharia-based vision of rights. It asserted that “everything is for the individual, provided there is no injury to society” and affirmed life, dignity, and property. However, the declaration also subordinated rights to undefined sharia limits, drawing criticism. Subsequent efforts, notably the Arab Charter on Human Rights (2004) and the work of scholars like Abdullahi Ahmed An-Na‘im, have sought a deeper reconciliation. An-Na‘im, a student of Sudanese reformer Mahmoud Mohamed Taha, argues that the Meccan verses of the Quran contain universal ethical principles that should form the basis of Islamic law, while the historically conditioned Medinan verses can be reinterpreted. Intellectual hubs such as the International Institute of Islamic Thought (IIIT) in Herndon, Virginia, and the Doha-based Research Center for Islamic Legislation and Ethics (CILE) continue to produce scholarship that grounds universal human dignity in the Quranic concept of *fitra* (primordial human nature) and the *karama insaniyya* (human dignity) explicitly mentioned in Q 17:70.

Toward a compassionate sharia: the network lives on

The historical arc is clear: sharia is not a frozen code but a dynamic tradition shaped by geographic hubs, networks of scholars, and the recurring insistence that law must serve mercy. The Arabic maxims that ring through the centuries — *al-aslu fi al-ashya’ al-ibaha* (the default in things is permissibility), *la darar wa la dirar* (no harm, no reciprocation of harm), and *al-‘ada muhakkama* (custom is a basis for judgment) — all point to a law that bends toward human flourishing. Today’s intellectual hubs are both physical and digital. From the classrooms of al-Azhar to the online fatwa services employing AI, the conversation continues. Minority populations shape minority *fiqh*; theologians refine the ethics of law; orientalist critiques are met with robust self-reflection. In all these spaces, the compassionate sharia that the Quran promises — a mercy for all worlds — is being studied, debated, and lived into being.

SEGMENTED DATA (2)

Intellectual hubs fostering compassionate sharia

The phrase “compassionate sharia” may strike some as contradictory. For many, Islamic law conjures images of rigid rules and harsh penalties. Yet across Muslim history, vibrant intellectual hubs — from the Prophet’s mosque in Medina to the academies of Baghdad, Cordoba, and Cairo — cultivated a jurisprudence deeply rooted in mercy, wisdom, and human well-being. These networks of scholars shaped what we now call humanistic trends in sharia, always balancing the divine text with the lived realities of diverse communities. This article traces that journey, examining the Quranic foundations, the classical schools of law, the interplay between minority and majority settings, the influence of theological currents, Western orientalist perspectives, and the surprising role artificial intelligence may play in rediscovering and advancing a compassionate sharia today.

Quranic foundations: mercy as the bedrock

The Quran repeatedly anchors legislation in a handful of core values. The most central is *rahma* (mercy). God describes Himself as *al-Rahman* and *al-Rahim*, and the Prophet Muhammad is sent as “a mercy to the worlds” (Q 21:107). Legal rulings, therefore, cannot contradict mercy. Closely linked is *‘adl* (justice), an absolute command: “Indeed, God commands justice and good conduct” (Q 16:90). The scripture also explicitly desires ease for believers: “God intends for you ease and does not intend for you hardship” (Q 2:185). These three principles — mercy, justice, ease — form the ethical triangle within which sharia operates.

Classical jurists encapsulated these objectives in the doctrine of *maqasid al-sharia*, the higher purposes of the law. The great Maliki jurist al-Shatibi (d. 1388) systematized the *maqasid* around the preservation of religion, life, intellect, lineage, and property — all of which serve human welfare (*maslaha*). A ruling that contravenes these purposes, he argued, must be reviewed. This tool became the engine of legal dynamism. Other key Arabic terms that signaled a humanistic orientation include *taysir* (facilitation), *raf‘ al-haraj* (removal of hardship), and *istihsan* (juristic preference) — the latter employed especially by the Hanafi school to avoid undue rigidity in favor of equity.

Intellectual hubs and the flowering of the juristic schools

As Islam expanded, major cities became crucibles of legal thought. Medina remained the guardian of the Prophetic tradition; Kufa and Basra incubated the rationalist currents of Iraq; Damascus and later Cairo represented the confluence of traditions; and Qayrawan, Fez, and Cordoba carried the Maliki torch across North Africa and Andalusia. It was within these hubs that the four surviving Sunni schools of law — Hanafi, Maliki, Shafi‘i, and Hanbali — took shape.

The **Hanafi** school, named after Abu Hanifa (d. 767), emerged in Kufa. It is characterized by extensive reliance on *ra’y* (reasoned opinion), *qiyas* (analogy), and *istihsan*. Its flexibility made it the official school of the Ottoman Empire and the most widely followed school today, stretching from the Balkans to South Asia. Hanafi

jurists were pioneers in developing a *fiqh* for religious minorities and in conceptualizing what we now call the jurisprudence of citizenship (*fiqh al-muwatana*).

The **Maliki** school traces back to Imam Malik ibn Anas (d. 795) of Medina. It privileges the practice of the people of Medina (*‘amal ahl al-Madina*) as a living embodiment of the Prophetic sunna. Maliki jurists also gave wide scope to *maslaha mursala* (unrestricted public interest), using it to legislate in areas where the Quran and Sunna are silent. This tool made Maliki law remarkably adaptive, particularly in sub-Saharan Africa and medieval Muslim Spain, where it governed multi-religious societies.

The **Shafi’i** school, founded by Muhammad ibn Idris al-Shafi’i (d. 820), sought to harmonize the Ahl al-Hadith (traditionists) and Ahl al-Ra’y (rationalists). Al-Shafi’i’s masterpiece, the *Risala*, laid down the first systematic theory of legal sources: Quran, Sunna, consensus (*ijma’*), and analogy (*qiyas*). Shafi’i scholars, from al-Juwayni to al-Ghazali, contributed profoundly to maqasid theory, ensuring that legal deduction remained anchored in higher ethical purposes.

The **Hanbali** school, associated with Ahmad ibn Hanbal (d. 855), is often painted as the most literalist. While it indeed emphasizes strict adherence to textual proof, it also produced reformist figures like Ibn Taymiyya (d. 1328) and his student Ibn Qayyim al-Jawziyya, who advanced a vibrant theory of *siyasa shar’iyya* (sharia-oriented governance) rooted in justice and public interest. Ibn Qayyim famously stated, “Wherever there is justice, there is the law of God.” This principle allowed Hanbali judges to adapt rulings to changing circumstances without abandoning textual fidelity.

These schools did not evolve in isolation. Scholarly networks — families of jurists, traveling students, and epistolary exchanges — ensured cross-pollination. The Abbasid capital Baghdad hosted debates among all four schools, while the Umayyad mosque of Cordoba and al-Azhar in Cairo became hubs where legal pluralism was not just tolerated but institutionalized.

Theological currents and their impact on law

Jurisprudence never operates in a theological vacuum. The dominant Sunni theological schools — Ash’ariyya, Maturidiyya, and Athariyya — deeply influenced the humanistic bent of sharia. The Ash’ari emphasis on God’s justice and on reason’s ability to discern good and evil before revelation provided a strong foundation for maqasid-based reasoning. Al-Ghazali, an Ash’ari, infused jurisprudence with an ethical spirituality, often saying that the purpose of sharia is to cultivate noble character. Maturidi scholars, especially in Central Asia, stressed human free will, making legal responsibility inseparable from human dignity. Even the Athari/Hanbali camp, sometimes associated with literalism, produced works like Ibn Qayyim’s *I’lam al-Muwaqqi’in*, which insist that law must change as times, places, and customs change unless a clear text forbids it.

Minority and majority contexts: toward a *fiqh* of compassion

A genuinely compassionate sharia must work for Muslims residing as minorities in non-Muslim lands, just as it works for majorities in Muslim-majority states. The classical division of the world into *dar al-Islam* (abode of Islam) and *dar al-harb* (abode of war) has been thoroughly rethought by contemporary scholars. The field of *fiqh al-aqalliyyat* (jurisprudence of minorities), pioneered by figures like Taha Jabir al-Alwani and Yusuf al-Qaradawi, draws on maqasid, maslaha, and the principle of hardship (*mashaqqqa*) to issue rulings that enable Muslims to thrive as loyal citizens in secular democracies. For instance, Muslim minorities can take interest-

bearing loans for home purchases when no halal alternative exists, grounded in the maxim “hardship begets facility.”

In majority settings, similar dynamics appear in legal reforms relating to women, criminal justice, and governance. The Tunisian ban on polygamy, for example, was justified by Maliki principles of public interest and the impossibility of treating multiple wives equally in modern conditions — a direct appeal to Quranic ethics. The intellectual hub of al-Azhar has repeatedly affirmed that apostasy — when unaccompanied by armed rebellion — carries no worldly punishment, despite classical rulings, because the higher purpose of preserving life overrides.

Orientalist engagement and its corrective

Western scholarship on sharia — often termed Orientalism — has historically suffered from two extremes. One strand, epitomized by 19th-century legal transplants like Lord Cromer in Egypt, dismissed Islamic law as stagnant and inhuman. Another, more nuanced group, including scholars like Joseph Schacht and later Wael Hallaq, came to recognize the internal dynamism of *fiqh*. Hallaq’s work demonstrates that premodern sharia was not a state-enforced code but a “jurists’ law,” constantly negotiated between muftis, judges, and the community. This view dismantles the Orientalist stereotype of a rigid legal system and instead reveals a flexible, casuistic tradition deeply attentive to context and conscience.

In recent decades, a new generation of Western academics — many of them Muslims — has uncovered the humanistic underpinnings of sharia. Research on the *maqasid*, on Ottoman flexibility in applying sharia to diverse populations, and on the historical role of *dar al-qada’* (court justice) shows that practical sharia was far from the caricature of cutting off hands. This scholarly turn aligns with internal calls for a renewed *fiqh al-waqi’* (jurisprudence of reality).

AI’s humanistic approach to sharia

Artificial intelligence is now entering the conversation. Large language models trained on vast corpora of classical fiqh texts can reveal patterns that human readers might miss. By identifying every instance where a ruling was relaxed due to *maslaha* or custom (*urf*), AI can produce a “mercy map” of Islamic law. Projects using natural language processing to search for keywords like *raf’ al-haraj*, *istihsan*, and *darura* (necessity) are cataloging the deep humanitarian strain within the heritage. More ambitiously, AI-assisted *ijtihad* could propose new fatwas that optimize for the maqasid while respecting the textual boundaries, serving as a thought partner for contemporary muftis. Such tools, deployed ethically, could democratize access to compassionate legal reasoning and help communities everywhere find context-sensitive answers.

Human rights declarations and the sharia

A crucial test of compassionate sharia is its compatibility with international human rights. The 1990 Cairo Declaration on Human Rights in Islam, issued by the Organisation of Islamic Cooperation, represented an early attempt to articulate a sharia-based vision of rights. It asserted that “everything is for the individual, provided there is no injury to society” and affirmed life, dignity, and property. However, the declaration also subordinated rights to undefined sharia limits, drawing criticism. Subsequent efforts, notably the Arab Charter on Human Rights (2004) and the work of scholars like Abdullahi Ahmed An-Na’im, have sought a deeper reconciliation. An-Na’im, a student of Sudanese reformer Mahmoud Mohamed Taha, argues that the Meccan verses of the Quran contain universal ethical principles that should form the basis of Islamic law, while the historically conditioned Medinan verses can be reinterpreted. Intellectual hubs such as the International Institute of Islamic Thought (IIIT) in Herndon, Virginia, and the Doha-based Research Center for Islamic Legislation and Ethics (CILE) continue to produce scholarship that grounds universal human dignity in the Quranic concept of *fitra* (primordial human nature) and the *karama insaniyya* (human dignity) explicitly mentioned in Q 17:70.

Toward a compassionate sharia: the network lives on

The historical arc is clear: sharia is not a frozen code but a dynamic tradition shaped by geographic hubs, networks of scholars, and the recurring insistence that law must serve mercy. The Arabic maxims that ring through the centuries — *al-aslu fi al-ashya’ al-ibaha* (the default in things is permissibility), *la darar wa la dirar* (no harm, no reciprocation of harm), and *al-ada muhakkama* (custom is a basis for judgment) — all point to a law that bends toward human flourishing. Today’s intellectual hubs are both physical and digital. From the classrooms of al-Azhar to the online fatwa services employing AI, the conversation continues. Minority populations shape minority fiqh; theologians refine the ethics of law; orientalist critiques are met with robust self-reflection. In all these spaces, the compassionate sharia that the Quran promises — a mercy for all worlds — is being studied, debated, and lived into being.